

FERNBANK MUSEUM - FAMILY VISIT PLANNING

Rush family | Membership current through July 2027

Fernbank is the family default for a Saturday-afternoon rainy-weather backup or a Sunday-post-church outing when Fritz has energy and Carter's Lego dinosaurs have started staring at him.

MEMBERSHIP LEVEL

Family Plus. Two adults plus all resident children. \$199 annual. Renewed August 2026. Includes IMAX, special exhibits, and reciprocal admission to CHOA-partnered science museums nationally (used it once in Denver with Florence).

REGULAR VISITS - carter's rotation

Carter (4, dinosaur-obsessed transitioning to dinosaur-plus-space) has three Fernbank stops he insists on every visit:

1. The Argentinosaurus in the atrium. Carter's first sentence about it was "biggest one". He now can recite length, weight, and where it lived. This remains the anchor.
2. The NatureQuest room (interactive Georgia ecosystems). Kids' area, safe for Ava in the carrier. Carter runs the same three interactive stations every visit.
3. The IMAX. Whichever documentary is playing. He has now seen the Kilimanjaro

film three times and has questions about mountain formation that Fritz cannot fully answer.

AVA'S ROUTE

Ava (1) is stroller-first with occasional carrier stretches. Best exhibits for her sight-line:

- The atrium windows (natural light, big spaces to look at)
- The NatureQuest room's low fish tank
- The Coca-Cola Great Hall (open, echoey, she likes the sound)

UPCOMING SPECIAL EXHIBITS TO PLAN AROUND

- "Wildlife Photographer of the Year" - through mid-December 2026. Diane particularly wants to see this. Plan a Saturday afternoon before Florence's Dec 18 arrival.
- "Deep Time: Cretaceous Predators" - opens January 2027. This will be Carter's Christmas-break priority. Plan the visit for the week of Dec 28.
- "Space and the Human Body" - opens spring 2027. Carter's dinosaur-to-space pivot targets this exhibit. Fritz already told him about it and Carter has been asking weekly.

VISIT CADENCE

Monthly. Usually second or third Saturday afternoon. Fritz's long-run days work best because the run leaves him fueled and calmer. Sunday afternoons are also options but compete with pot roast prep.

FOOD

Cafe on-site is fine for a quick lunch. Fritz's preference is to eat at home first (or grab something at the Buford Highway Farmers Market on the way if the day allows for a food-culture detour). Ava is stroller-fed at any time.

PARKING

The garage under Ponce City Market has been our workaround when Fernbank's own lot is full. Ten-minute walk with the double stroller. Not ideal in rain.

FUTURE

Fernbank membership decision at renewal in August 2027 depends on where the family lives after fellowship. If we buy in Decatur or Avondale Estates it stays. If we move further, the Fernbank membership converts to something local. Not a current decision.

FOSSIL SHOP

Carter has now spent his allowance on a Deinonychus tooth model, a Triceratops

skull magnet, and a paperback field guide to dinosaurs. The fossil shop is the exit ritual. Fritz has a rule: one item under \$15. Carter has learned the rule and mostly respects it.

BIRDING CROSSOVER

Fernbank Forest walk after the museum works for the pre-dawn-run habit Fritz has built in reverse - a slower, careful walk with the Merlin app looking for Red-shouldered Hawks and warblers in migration. Carter has started to point out birds himself which is more than Fritz expected at age 4.

NOTE ON CROWDS

Sundays after 2 PM are the least crowded window. Saturday mornings are worst. IMAX shows on the hour, arrive 15 minutes early for seat choice with kids.